

The Little Ice Age

Between 1300 and 1850, Earth underwent a period of widespread cooling when glaciers advanced in many places around the world. Today, climatologists refer to this as the Little Ice Age, but the idea of an Ice Age was not understood until the 19th century. Until then it was thought that each area of the world had a fixed climate. We now know that climate change occurs in cycles, and may be affected by factors such as increased volcanic activity, changes in ocean circulation, and a fall in solar energy reaching Earth. The winter of 1683–1684 was particularly harsh in northern Europe and the Thames River in London froze over for two months. When the ice was at its thickest, a frost fair was held on the river.

